

All Work And No Pay

Unless you're a pirate, setting up software for a small office involves money. Or so you thought. The good news is, you don't need to spend a penny. You do need to spend some time, though—the time needed to read this book! We're going to tell you about the free software available for your basic needs, and how to use them.

We wonder why more people don't use OpenOffice.org... it's free, and it's almost as feature-rich as Microsoft Office. Half this book is devoted to an introduction to the components of OOo: Writer (think MS Word), Impress (think PowerPoint), and the others. Assuming you haven't used that suite, we walk you through the basics. Luckily, there isn't too much to re-learn even if you and your employees are used to MS Office, as you'll find. The good folks beyond the development of OpenOffice have taken pains to ensure there isn't too much pain involved in the getting-unused-to. Keyboard shortcuts, for example, are the same in many cases.

Then there's the mail client that your office needs, of course, and we have a section devoted to that. Thunderbird is the answer, and it's not just company mail: we discuss how you can configure that software to be your client for your Gmail as well, and more.

Being able to collaborate on documents irrespective of location is a necessity now, and that paradigm can only gain in popularity. For that we have the Zoho suite. We've gone into considerable detail to explain how you can use Zoho as effectively as possible. Now, if you're worrying that using Zoho might take up some precious learning time, here's to put you at ease (with the example of Zoho Writer)—you can go to the URL and work using your browser; you can install an MS Office plugin that allows you to work on your documents from within Word; or you install a simple Widget so Zoho looks like it's on your Desktop. That indicates the kind of flexibility the creators of Zoho want to give you—for free!

We love feedback. Really. Do write in and tell us if this book helped.